

# Cookies in Iran

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# Who you gonna call?

My journey began some time ago in a car you do not see every day: a 1993 Mercedes W124, a former emergency doctor's vehicle. With its distinctive build, it looks a bit like the wagon of the Ghostbusters. And that is exactly how it felt: like an adventure where you never know which ghost is waiting around the next corner. The W124 was my home on wheels, a faithful steel tank that carried me across a vast tapestry of cultures and landscapes.

Yet, no country on this journey captivated or challenged me as deeply as Iran.

What I am about to tell you is only a fraction of my experiences there. It is the story of what was arguably the most adventurous, yet nerve-wracking month of my life. It was a time when the boundless kindness of people collided head-on with the cold, unyielding rigidity of a merciless system.

I know the pages ahead might seem daunting, but please read until the end. I promise you: it will be worth it. You will come to understand how a simple box of cookies in a ruthless system can suddenly hold the power to decide one's freedom and fate.

# Do Not Pass Go

My passport has been gone for nearly a week at this point. I sit in uncertainty, yet I remain calm. Normally, I am an optimistic person; I solve problems as they arise rather than letting them overwhelm me. So Payam and I enter the courthouse with an open mind. It will be fine, I tell myself.

This is already my second visit there, but more on that later.

We enter the office of the court assistant, who is impeccably groomed. A brief exchange of words, then the signal: the judge is ready for us. We move into the judge's chambers. The room is bleak: a simple wooden table where the judge is enthroned, surrounded by metal chairs with leather seats that have apparently been sitting in their original plastic packaging for years. Better not risk any wear and tear, just to be safe. I take a seat at the side while Payam sits directly across from the judge.

The atmosphere in the room is oppressive. Payam usually has this friendly, relaxed look in his eyes that inspires immediate trust. But as the two of them speak, I watch that look change. He becomes serious, then deeply concerned. I do not understand a single word of the Persian

dialogue, but unease slowly creeps up my spine. The conversation lasts barely two minutes, yet they feel like an eternity.

When we leave the room, there is silence at first. Payam searches for words. He probably realizes in this moment that there is no right way to phrase what he has to tell me.

"Anton," he says finally, his voice heavy, "they are accusing you of smuggling your car into Iran. We have to come back in two days. With a bail of \$48,000. If we do not have the money, you go to prison."

I look at him and ask only: "Are you serious or are you joking?"

He looks at me and confirms that it is no joke.

\$48,000. A sum completely beyond my reality. Only one absurd thought pops into my head: Do not pass go. Do not collect \$4,000.

Great!

We walk silently to the car and drive off.

# Between Rockets and Red Sand

After a three-month stay in Thailand, I returned to Tbilisi, the capital of Georgia, at the end of February 2025. I picked up Ketik from Armenia, whom I already knew from Southeast Asia, and we spent some time in Georgia until we had all the necessary documents together. The visas for Iran were issued very quickly and without any problems. However, the arrival of the Carnet de Passage took its time. This document is similar to a passport, but not for people, but for cars. To get one, you have to leave a deposit depending on the value of the car. In my case, it was 5,000 euros.

When the Carnet finally arrived, we decided to head toward Iran quite quickly, as I really wanted to experience the Nowruz celebrations. So we made our way through Armenia's breathtaking mountain landscapes and arrived in Iran on March 17. At the border, it quickly became clear that things were not really organized. The Carnet was already stamped, but I was told to go see a man in a container. He made several calls but did not seem to get the necessary information; however, he appeared very relaxed and indifferent and finally just let me go.

By now, I am aware of what his problem was: by law, he is actually obliged to give me an exit date for the car. Apparently, he was not aware of when that was. Neither was I, personally. Generally, it is very difficult as a foreigner to obtain legal information from within Iran. This is not only due to the language barrier, but also because all Iranian websites are only available from within Iran. At that moment, I did not understand exactly what this man's problem was. I did not care either; I was glad that he simply let us drive.

Iran was exciting and different from anywhere else I had been. Over the next few weeks, we drove via Tabriz, Rasht, Tehran, and Isfahan to Shiraz. After about a month of traveling together, Ketī had to leave again. I continued my tour alone and spent another month in the south of the country. Since a liter of gasoline costs just 2 cents, I naturally took advantage of that and visited numerous places and islands. My absolute recommendation is the island of Hormuz. I have never seen nature like this: from the ground of yellow crystal rock to deep red and sparkling black sand, this island really has a lot to offer.

From Hormuz, I went back to the island of Qeshm, where I met Alen. He is a slender, tall Croatian with a beard and a friendly smile who had already been traveling with his VW T4 for over nine years. He was stranded on the island because he had a major problem with his van. Since I had not drunk any alcohol for two months previously, the change was welcome: Alen had a connection to



an Arak dealer. We drank the moonshine together and talked about our plans. Alen mentioned that he had left his van in Iran for a longer period of time twice before. He said it was no problem as long as the Carnet is still valid. Looking back, the lesson is clear: never trust a drunk Croatian when it comes to complex legal regulations. At that time, however, I did not give it any thought, as I was on my way to Nepal.

On May 7, it was time for us to leave the island. With a tow rope, I pulled Alen's T4 toward the ferry. We drove in the scorching heat of 40 degrees at 30 km/h across the roads. My W124 has no air conditioning, which I had gotten used to at these temperatures, but it did not exactly make the trip more relaxed. On the ferry, we sat with the employees and drank tea. I told them that I was on my way to Nepal via Pakistan and India. One of the men made rocket movements with his hands from India to Pakistan. I thought he meant the skirmishes in the Kashmir conflict, which were escalating again, and assumed that they would calm down as they had before.

I was wrong. When we arrived on the mainland, I checked the news. There it was in black and white: India had attacked Pakistan with rockets that day. This was a much bigger deal than the few small skirmishes before. I realized that the border between India and Pakistan would remain closed. My plan did not work out. I decided to keep a cool head and booked a hotel room in Bandar Abbas to do some online research. There, I found confirmation of Alen's statement in numerous travel forums

and blogs. There were now two options: either I drive via Pakistan to Afghanistan and further toward Tajikistan, or I leave the car in Iran and fly back to Southeast Asia. The latter seemed much more attractive than dealing with the Taliban in Afghanistan. I decided to sleep on it. The next morning, I booked my ticket for May 12 from Shiraz to Bangkok and made my way to Shiraz.

Once there, I met Razool, Alen's mechanic. Razool is an immensely kind man with bright eyes and a very positive aura whose heart beats for VWs. He offered to let me park my car on his private property. It seemed like the best option to me, and I gratefully accepted the offer.

On my day of departure on May 12, there was an unexpected obstacle. In the great heat of the last few weeks, I had become indifferent to the fact that, according to Sharia law, one should actually not wear short pants. For foreigners, somewhat different laws generally apply in Iran. Since I was flying to Bangkok, I did not have a single pair of long pants with me. At the airport, an officer told me I could not fly like that. He searched my luggage but, of course, found nothing. I suggested tying my large Decathlon towel around my legs like a skirt. He agreed. So I sat in the waiting hall with my tied-on towel and finally boarded the plane.

# Between Worlds

The following months I spent in Thailand, Laos, Vietnam, China, and Japan. I was far away from the bureaucratic hurdles of the Middle East. While I traveled through these countries, my Mercedes remained, believed to be safe, in Shiraz on private property. But the geopolitical situation in Iran changed abruptly in June 2025 due to the 12-day war. Heavy air strikes by Israel and the USA hit the country. In the midst of this time of instability, Razool contacted me. He asked for photos of my passport and the Carnet de Passage. He justified this by saying that the police might ask. As I later learned, Razool had reported to the Iranian secret service because my foreign vehicle was parked on his property. In a time of extreme military paranoia, the car was at least officially known to the authorities and not hidden.

Parallel to this, the situation also changed for Alen. He also had to leave his T4 in Iran because a repair on-site was not possible. He informed me that leaving the vehicle, contrary to his first assumption, could lead to massive problems. Alen himself had been very lucky with his deadline overrun, which ran parallel to mine, and only paid about 70 euros. I then began to research more intensively myself. I came across reports according to which a

fine of about 1,000 euros would be due for the overstay. For me, that was a calculable risk and rather a high fee for my gained freedom of travel in Southeast Asia.

Since I was already in a legal bind because of the deadline overrun anyway, I saw no reason for a rushed return. I decided to wait until the military situation in the country had calmed down a bit. Shortly before my planned return trip, there was contact with Razool again. He helped me repair the alternator on my Mercedes so that the car was ready for the upcoming journey. On December 30, 2025, I finally landed at Imam Khomeini Airport in Tehran. Entry went without any major problems. Nevertheless, the atmosphere upon my arrival was tense. At that point, I was not yet aware of how much the situation in the country had intensified. I returned to a country that, after the war in the summer, was now burning from within; it was the second day of the large nationwide protests.

# In the Vacuum of the Blackout

After my landing, I first spent a few days in Tehran before taking the night train to Shiraz. I was very much looking forward to returning to this place, which is one of my favorites in the whole country. This was partly due to the friendship with the host of my hotel, and partly because I could finally take delivery of my Mercedes again. Jalal, his wife Zara, and her brother Ali received me very warmly in their home. It is a beautiful house in the old Iranian style with colorful windows overlooking the green courtyard. Due to the nationwide protests, I stayed in the house most of the time and almost only went out to eat. There was a familiar atmosphere, and I spent a lot of time talking to the other guests.

Since Razool was at a VW meeting in Bushehr for a few days, I had to wait a bit for my car. When I finally picked it up, it was buried under a thick layer of dust. I sat down inside and turned the key. The car started immediately, just as I was used to. Even though the Mercedes looked a bit run-down from the outside and inside, the engine ran like a charm. However, the rust in some places had become much more visible over the months. Since repairs

in Iran were extremely cheap compared to Germany, I looked for a painter through Razool. We agreed on a price of about 200 euros. For this sum, he painted the trunk lid, the hood, and several small spots around the car. He also ground off an old external socket and welded in a new piece of sheet metal.

The waiting time for the painting was no problem, as I had to go to Tehran again anyway. My Russian passport was at the consulate, which remained closed for the New Year celebrations until January 12. Before I handed the car over to the painter, I spent hours looking for winter tires. My planned route was supposed to take me through the mountains of the Kurdish part of Iran and later to Armenia. I discovered that summer tires were definitely no fun there. But the search remained unsuccessful. People often did not even understand what I was looking for or offered me snow chains, which were also not available. I finally gave up and brought the Mercedes to the painter.

On Wednesday, January 7, the tension in the country became clearly visible. I wanted to find something to eat, but although it was a normal weekday, all the shops were closed. It was a frightening sight, but at the same time exciting to see how strongly the population held together through this boycott against the regime. The true horror followed the next day when the internet was simply switched off throughout the entire country. At first, I thought of a brief outage for the weekend, but I was wrong. Since only national websites still worked, Jalal was at least able to book train tickets to Tehran

for me. After I picked up my car in perfectly painted condition on Friday, I set off on Sunday evening by night train to the capital.

On Monday morning, I arrived in Tehran and was the first in line in front of the consulate. There, they told me that my passport was present, but that I actually could not receive it because of the blackout, as the collection had to be reported to Moscow. After a long discussion, I was lucky because I was additionally traveling with my German passport. They finally handed the document over to me, but warned me that the passport would only be activated in the system once internet was available again. I was relieved because a new passport would have been a huge effort and I had to leave Iran as quickly as possible. Before the return trip, I still visited the German embassy. I hoped desperately for a way to reach my parents, who knew about my stay in Iran but were hit completely unexpectedly by the sudden blackout. However, there was no possibility for a connection to the outside world.

Back in Shiraz, I spent one last night at Jalal's as his only guest. The next day, the days-long drive through the picturesque mountain landscape of the Iranian West toward Tabriz began. Since I had at least one Iranian navigation app, I made good progress. The forced digital detox initially even felt like freedom, as I could finally spend hours with my favorite activity, driving. Nevertheless, the checks were hard on me: I was stopped at almost every station, my car was searched, and once I was even

held for a two-hour interview. With every kilometer toward the north, the concern for my loved ones at home grew, while the border to Armenia slowly came closer.



# Icy Standstill

On Tuesday, January 20, 2026, I woke up in my hotel in Tabriz, had breakfast in peace, and finally got ready for the drive to Norduz at the border. Shortly after setting out, it became apparent that this day would not necessarily be my best. The temperatures had dropped noticeably compared to the previous days, and heavy snowfall set in. Although I had specially bought windshield washer fluid with antifreeze in advance, the agent proved to be completely ineffective; it seemed to be little more than blue-colored water. Due to the kicked-up slush and the dirt from the road, my windshield was already so dirty after a few minutes that I could hardly see anything.

Fortunately, my W124 had a heated washer system. Initially, the heat of the liquid even helped to bring the wiper blade, which was already slightly deformed by the cold, back to its original shape. But following the 'more is more' motto, I used ever larger amounts of the heated water. This proved to be a fatal mistake: the liquid stayed on the wiper blade, and under the influence of the icy airstream, the whole thing froze abruptly on the highway. The previously elastic and curved wiper turned into a rigid, straight rod that no longer had any contact with the glass. My vision was almost completely blocked as a

result.

With great difficulty, I made it to a gas station with a small kiosk attached. I asked the owner for a proper antifreeze, and fortunately, he had a suitable product in stock. I poured the liquid directly over the windshield wiper, but the centimeter-thick layer of ice was completely unimpressed. When I asked the kiosk owner for advice, he had a pragmatic solution ready: he filled boiling water from his samovar into a kettle and helped me thaw the mechanism by hand. I was relieved and happy to finally be able to continue my journey with clear vision.

A little later, however, the next surprise followed. I had driven about 1,600 kilometers from Shiraz to Tabriz and had passed through almost continuously snowy landscapes in which the roads, however, were always perfectly cleared. Why I had ended up on a completely snowed-in section of the highway at this of all times was an absolute mystery to me. With my summer tires, I crept across the asphalt at just 20 km/h. It took about an hour until the road conditions improved again. Marked by the hardships of this journey, I finally reached the border in Norduz after a total of four hours.

Upon my arrival, I felt somewhat prepared. I had drafted a letter in which I described my situation and asked to keep a possible fine small. My plan was to obtain a document certifying that everything was in order with my car. With a little luck, I then even wanted to continue

toward the Turkish border, as this was my actual goal to start the journey back to Europe.

I parked the Mercedes in front of the border, got out, and oriented myself briefly. At that moment, a man approached me, about 1.80 meters tall, corpulent, with a friendly smile. He seemed to me like a trader and spoke to me in English that was unusually good for Iranian standards. I explained my situation and that I needed this document. He showed me the way, whereupon I first passed the first barrier on foot. I had had the correct department noted on a small slip of paper, which I was now looking for.

The man with glasses now went with me to a few other offices. The officials there skimmed my letter rather indifferently and spoke in Farsi while doing so. However, one term emerged that I noticed, even though I did not understand it: Tasirat. In the office of the customs chief, my Carnet de Passage and my passport were finally confiscated. Glasses handed me a copy on which he noted the receipt of my passport and wrote down his phone number. In the end, we checked whether the chassis number of the car matched the number on the Carnet. I then asked him if there would be a problem and mentioned that I had the feeling of being the first one with such a problem, since we had talked to so many people before. He simply answered with No, no problem! and smiled. I thought to myself: Okay, then everything is fine. He told me to go to the hotel and come back the next morning to go to court. I assumed that the court would merely

calculate the fine for the overstay and I could then pay it there. I was not very happy about the situation, but I did not see it as a major existential problem now either.

With my passport copy, I tried to check into the local hotel. However, the employee did not know whether he was allowed to take me in since I did not have an original passport and the responsible office was currently closed. He asked me to come back in an hour. In this context, it must be mentioned that when checking in in Iran, you have to hand over your passport at the hotel as long as you stay there. Of the 42 countries I have traveled to, it is the only one with this strange rule, which applies to both foreigners and Iranians.

I first went to the restaurant next door to bridge the waiting time with a soup and kebab. A little later, the man I had met shortly before at the border also entered the room and sat down with me. While we ate, I explained my situation to him, whereupon he made fun of my gullibility a bit; he said the customs officers had probably used a pretext to get me to drive my car voluntarily onto the fenced-off area. I did not think much of it. He told me that he had lived in Australia and Dubai for several years, which explained his fluent English. There was a pragmatic reason why he was spending time here of all places at the border: he possessed an Armenian SIM card that dialed into the neighboring network here in the border area. In the midst of the nationwide blackout, this was the only place far and wide with working internet. He was so helpful as to let me use his cell phone so that I

could finally give my parents a sign of life. He introduced himself as Payam, and I saved his number directly in my cell phone. After dinner, he accompanied me back to the hotel and helped me check in, where the staff finally accepted the passport copy thanks to his mediation. I said goodbye to him in the firm belief that I could continue my journey the next day without much ado.

# The Sealed Fate

The next morning, I went back to the border to meet Glasses. He told me directly that the judge was not in the house that day and I would have to wait until Saturday. I should appear again at nine in the morning so that he could drive to court with me. He made a friendly impression and spoke a little English, which left me in the belief that everything would go according to plan. It was not an ideal situation, but I had no other choice but to agree.

When leaving the border area, I happened to meet Payam and told him about the postponement. He asked me if we should go in again together to talk to Glasses. Since I still assumed at this point that I only had to go to court to pay the fine for the car's overstay, I declined. I did not want to cause any trouble. That was a big mistake, as would turn out later.

We went with Payam to eat sandwiches and talked about everything under the sun. I also saved Payam's Armenian number via WhatsApp. After that, we looked for a suitable SIM card for me. It would have been easy to get one if I could have left the country, but without a passport and with the one-way visa, that was not possible. After some searching, we found a dealer for pre-activated cards.

The second one we tested worked perfectly. I was happy to finally have internet again after almost two weeks. We also got a gas camping stove for me so that I could prepare something in the hotel. After that, we said goodbye and I went back to the hotel.

The next two days passed rather unspectacularly. I used the time to catch up on the news I had missed during the blackout. In doing so, I learned about the bloody massacre the government had committed against protesters in the shadow of digital darkness. It is a terrible feeling to learn what atrocities happened around you while you yourself were cut off from any kind of news. In addition, I worked on the website for my future company. On Friday, I wanted to call Payam to coordinate for the next day, but his number was suddenly nowhere to be found. I could not explain this at all, since I had seen it when saving it via WhatsApp.

On Saturday morning, I was at the border on time at nine o'clock, but there was no sign of Glasses. After an hour, I asked a woman in his department about him. She called him, but since she did not speak English, there was no real communication. She printed a letter, sealed it, wrote an address on the envelope, pointed her finger at it and said only: Taxi. I looked for a driver outside who took me to the court in Jolfa, about 50 minutes away, for the equivalent of 7 euros. The price was quite expensive by Iranian standards, but I had no other choice.

Arriving at the court, the taxi driver grabbed the let-

ter and went in with me. I had actually expected that Glasses would already be waiting for me there, but he was not. The taxi driver first went to the judge's assistant. We had to wait. Due to the excitement, I had to go to the toilet and typed into my cell phone translator whether there was one here. The assistant did not answer me. Instead, he apparently made fun of me by saying something to the other visitors and laughing. A really great place. After ten minutes, the judge had time for us. The taxi driver and I went in and the two talked in Farsi while I could only stand by.

The taxi driver made a hand movement that we could go and showed me a three with his fingers as we went out. I did not understand if he meant three hours or three days. Outside, I gave him my cell phone so that he could write what was going on with the translator. At that moment, reality hit me like a blow: the taxi driver was simply not able to write. I stared at him and did not understand at all what had just happened. There I stood, had absolutely no idea what was legally coming my way, and my only bridge to this judicial apparatus was a man who could not operate a single key on my cell phone. It was an absurd, almost frightening moment of total isolation. Outside stood a few other men. I asked them with hand gestures if they could write down what the taxi driver said. One typed into my cell phone and I read in the translation app: 3 days. That was a disaster, since in three days would be the last day of my visa.

I went back to the judge and showed him via the transla-



tor that my visa expired in three days. I made gestures that he could communicate with me via the translator, but he only made a hand gesture that he did not want to take my phone. Since my cell phone was blocked in Iran, I could not call anyone myself. I pointed to his phone and made a phone gesture, but he refused that too. I went out and found a man who allowed me to call with his smartphone. I called Jalal from Shiraz, whom I had already forewarned. I wanted to give the phone to the judge, but he refused again. The assistant was in the room at the time and went back to his workplace. I followed him and gave him the phone. He took it but was visibly unwilling to talk to Jalal. He gave the phone back to me and said to the others present with a shake of his head something about Hotel Shiraz. Jalal told me on the phone that the man was super rude. He told me that they claimed to want to help me so that I would not have to go to prison. Jalal, however, perceived that at the moment as if that were just talk and the situation was not so bad.

The assistant now pressed a letter into the taxi driver's hand, and he signed for receipt of it. We made our way back to Norduz. Arriving there, the taxi driver waved the letter to the border guard as if it were extremely important. I felt only contempt for this man who apparently had no feeling for what kind of situation he had brought me into. We went into the building and he gave the letter to an employee. There was some back and forth until a person in charge was determined. The man told me to come back in an hour.

Hardly had I left the border when I got a call. I looked at the phone and saw Payam's Armenian WhatsApp name. I do not know if it is just me, but when I add a number to an existing contact on WhatsApp, the name is often simply overwritten by the contact's profile name. I had noticed that before, but in this stressful time, I had simply forgotten it. I was happy and told him about the exchange of letters. After dinner, I went back to customs. The officer finished writing a letter and brought it together with me to his superior. On his table, I saw a very long number in the document. I took out my cell phone, converted the number, and thought that was a \$1,600 fine. The superior, however, calculated again and turned the calculator toward me. I had overlooked a zero. \$16,000.

My heart stopped, and my jaw literally dropped. The mustachioed customs chief simply nodded at the number on inquiry, as if it were the most normal thing in the world. I was paralyzed with shock. The superior folded the letter, sealed the envelope, and said only a single word: Problem. He made me understand that I would have to take this sealed letter back to the court in Jolfa the next day. I had to catch my breath for a moment before I typed into my cell phone that I would need a copy of this letter because it was about me after all and I would probably need a lawyer now. He thought for a moment, but then actually printed out the letter. However, he tore off almost everything from it and only left the narrow strip with the number. Another number,

probably the case number, he additionally made unrecognizable with a ballpoint pen. I took this scrap of paper and left the border. I no longer knew which way was up. It was a shock I had not known in this form before, as I usually remain very focused even in stressful situations. Here, however, I just felt completely powerless. In this state, I called Payam and described everything to him. He immediately offered me to come to him in Tabriz, stay overnight there, and go to court together the next day. I accepted the invitation and set off for Tabriz by taxi.

# The 16,000-Dollar Tank

The drive to Tabriz took about three hours. Halfway there, I changed from the taxi into a collective taxi, in which sat an Iranian from Dubai who spoke fluent English. I told him and the taxi driver my entire story and showed him the snippet with the alleged fine. The man, however, quickly enlightened me: the 16,000 dollars was not my fine, but the value of my car set by customs. This information calmed me down a bit. I showed him a photo of my car, and we joked together about the fact that this old Mercedes was actually valued at such a sum.

Arriving in the city, I was received by Payam and his friend Saleh. Saleh is a rather small but very agile man with alert eyes, a confident demeanor, and a radiant toothpaste smile. He has only little hair left on his head, but those he has are always perfectly groomed. He worked as a manager at the Tabriz airport, the capital of the East Azerbaijan province, and therefore had very good contacts in the entire region, where the Norduz border crossing is also located, the place on the Armenian border where my car had been detained. We drove to a mall, where Saleh made several phone calls to find a solution. Since nothing promising emerged for the time being, we drove to Payam's home. He was so

hospitable as to leave me his own room while he himself slept on the couch in the living room.

The next morning, we made our way to the court in Jolfa. It was not so easy to find the right building. On the way, we asked a passerby for directions who apparently knew the place very well. He told us that he had already had 15 cases with my responsible judge and that he was a real asshole. This assessment coincided with what I had already heard several times from other people at the border. I seriously wondered at that moment why I of all people had to run into this man.

Arriving at the right court, the assistant told us that the judge was not present. So it was another lost day, to which I was slowly getting used. We decided to drive back to Norduz to officially question the exaggerated value of the car. At first, things didn't look too bad: we asked our way from office to office until the chief of the responsible employee finally wrote a handwritten note on a piece of paper. With this note, we went back to the employee who had set the value.

But he then explained to us unmistakably that the value was fixed and he had already chosen this value as small as possible with benevolence. If we wanted to contest this, we would have to settle that via Tehran, which would however take two to three weeks. In retrospect, Payam also explained to me the absurd logic behind the valuation: since the official could not find my car in the system, he simply took a Mercedes from 2018 as a basis. He de-

ducted 25 years of loss in value and additionally levied a luxury tax of 70%. It was a deeply professional approach, exactly as one imagines for a border official in Norduz. Since we could do nothing further, we spent the night in the hotel I already knew at the border area.

# No Problem, It Is Just 18,000 Euros

The next morning, we set out again for Jolfa to the court. The groomed assistant made the impression as if he had already been waiting for us. The judge has time for you now, he signaled briefly.

We entered the judge's chambers. I took a seat at the side while Payam sat directly across from the judge. The two began their conversation in Farsi. I watched Payam's face, which became more worried from second to second. Although I did not understand a word, unease crept up in me. After barely two minutes, we left the room again.

You surely know what is coming now. Pay \$48,000. Do not pass go. Do not collect \$4,000. Here, the significance of the previously chosen car value of \$16,000 suddenly became clear. It is common practice in Iran to set the fine in a smuggling case at three times the value of the goods, which is why the security deposit corresponded to this sum.

We drove back to Norduz speechless. On the way, it occurred to me that the moment had now come to report

to the German embassy. I dialed the number and explained my situation. The woman at the other end of the line told me briefly and concisely that she would pass the case on and someone would get in touch with me.

Shortly thereafter, a Mrs. Jäger actually got in touch with me. She seemed very eloquent and extremely rational on the phone, which had a strangely calming effect on me in this chaos. Even if no concrete solution resulted from this first phone call, we left it that she would try to draft an official letter. Above all, it should be explained therein that I was forced to leave the car in Iran due to the warlike situation between Pakistan and India. The problem, however, was that at that time there was still no internet in Iran. She was therefore unsure whether she could have sent me the letter at all.

Arriving in Norduz, we wanted to try to talk to Glasses again in the hope of somehow improving our position. But nothing came of this plan. Instead, he told us about an agreement that the customs chief had probably already reached with the judge via the informal channels. They wanted to have the matter off the table quickly.

The agreement provided for a fine of 55% of the set car value. In reverse, however, this also meant that I would be officially convicted of having smuggled the car. Casually, he also mentioned that he himself had only filed the report six days before my arrival at the border. Had I been there only a week earlier, I would have been spared all this fun. How fate plays out sometimes.



I had been proud all my life that I had actually never felt hatred for anyone. Mostly, I can understand very well why people act as they act. In this moment, however, the motives couldn't matter less to me. I now felt a deep hatred for Glasses. All I could think was how this person had treated me: starting with his No, no problem on the first day to the promise to accompany me to court, which he then did not do after all. He knew exactly that I would not even find out there without Persian skills what I was being accused of, and yet he had simply let me drive there alone in the taxi.

I calculated the damage: 8,000 euros fine, 5,000 euros my deposit for the Carnet, and the car that I would now never get back. Total financial damage: 18,000 euros, regardless of the fact that my heart really is attached to this Mercedes.

We left the border area and went to the hotel.

# The Bitter Tear of Freedom

After the return to the hotel, there was an almost tangible tension. Payam was immediately immersed in phone calls, his voice a constant murmur in the background. I retreated to the next room to reach my parents. It was one of those conversations you never want to have. I had to tell them about the dramatic development, about the astronomical bail and the threatening reality that I could soon end up in an Iranian prison.

When I ended the conversation, I stepped to the window. My gaze wandered over in the direction of Armenia. Over there, only a few hundred meters away, lay the freedom that seemed so unreachable at this moment. In this instant, I broke down. I cried bitterly, tears of pure helplessness and exhaustion. I could not remember when I had last lost control like that. But strangely, it felt good. When the tears dried up, the paralyzing sadness had given way to a cool determination. I realized that I must not simply sit in the corner and wait for my fate. I knew I had to act somehow, but also noticed that I was no longer master of the situation alone.

Although I had never been a great fan of presenting my-

self on social media, and my posts had become rather rare in the course of the journey, I now decided to look for help on Instagram. I published a post in which I looked for someone who could help me with legal problems in Iran. The response was overwhelming. Countless people got in touch, and I tried to answer everyone but simply could no longer keep up after a short time. It is really exciting how people react in such moments. Most of them only asked worriedly how I was doing or gave the well-meaning but not very helpful advice to report to the German embassy. In such an extreme situation, that is of course not particularly conducive. But between all the noise, there were a few messages that were really structured and offered a real option.

In my desperation, I also contacted MC Basstard, a German rapper and Iran activist with whom I had already been in contact a few times because of my trip. He recommended an Iranian lawyer from Berlin. The phone call with him, however, was a punch in the gut. One of the first things he said to me was: You must realize that you are now a hostage. Even if my mind told me that rationally there were no signs of a political hostage-taking yet, such a sentence stings deeply when you already have your back against the wall anyway.

I remembered the letter from the embassy again for which I was waiting so urgently. Since I assumed, however, that the sending would fail due to the missing internet, I decided on a direct attempt at the Foreign Office in Berlin. My hope was simple: maybe they could issue the docu-

ment to me directly from Germany.

After I had fought my way through the hold music of the hotline, I reached an employee and began to describe my situation. But hardly had the word Iran been mentioned when I was interrupted. She explained to me in a lecturing tone that a travel warning had been issued for the country. I confirmed calmly that I was aware of that and tried to continue with my story. Before I could get to the core of the matter, however, she interrupted me two more times to point out the travel warning to me again. Finally, I lost my patience; I replied to her that I understood the principle, but I was now in this situation and her lectures were anything but helpful at this moment.

After we had laboriously synchronized, she promised to forward me. But with the next colleague, exactly the same spectacle was offered. He did not let me finish and held the travel warning up to me a total of three times. I am fully aware that I cannot expect major assistance when I enter a country for which an official warning exists. Nevertheless, it should be possible after a one-time lecture to either listen to what the actual problem consists of or to communicate directly if no support can be provided. In such an extreme situation, this bureaucratic ping-pong is pure torture for someone who is in really big trouble. After all, I did not demand a military evacuation, but merely a short letter for the court.

When I could finally make him understand that I needed a confirmation for the court about the India-Pakistan

conflict that had forced me to leave the car behind, there came only a dry: All right, I will pass that on. To my question where he was passing that on to, he replied curtly: to the embassy. The embassy that was already informed anyway and could not send me anything because of the blackout. That was the sobering result of a twenty-minute phone call that could also have been handled in two minutes.

The rest of the evening I spent as if in a trance writing messages, but a real solution did not materialize. My head throbbed from the hours of conversations; I couldn't think straight. At some point, I dragged myself over to Payam. We talked briefly about the further plans. He said we would drive to Tabriz the next day to meet Saleh. He would find a solution. I just thought: Okay, without having much hope.

Before I went over again, Payam also told me that the Americans had arrived in the Persian Gulf with the aircraft carrier Abraham Lincoln. Oh yes, there was that too...

I lay down in bed, unable to exchange another word. Sleep was out of the question. The idea of ending up in jail in Iran was one thing. I would somehow deal with that. I would not be the first foreigner that happens to, and I was sure that most of the prisoners there are normal citizens who would rather help me. But what was much worse than just being in a cell: the idea that war would break out soon and I would then end up as a pris-

oner directly as a pawn between the front lines. That I would then no longer just be stuck because of a car but would end up as a bargaining chip in a military conflict. This thought triggered a completely different kind of fear. Only after hours of mental exhaustion did I finally fall asleep.

# The Law of the Box

We woke up early the next morning and set off for Tabriz. Since my passport was gone, various escape scenarios went through my head. The car and the Carnet didn't matter to me at this moment; it was just about getting out of there somehow. The security situation had deteriorated dramatically since the previous day.

I was relatively sure that no note of my court hearing existed in the central system, since the Iranian systems are not widely networked with each other. My plan was therefore to go to the foreigners' police, fake the loss of my passport, and apply for an exit visa with my second German passport. That was also the recommendation of Mrs. Jäger from the embassy. I wanted to wait and see what Saleh could achieve in Tabriz first, but that was definitely my plan B if the situation did not improve abruptly.

Arriving in Tabriz, we picked up Saleh. He explained to us that we would drive directly to the supreme judge for smuggling matters of the province, whom he knew well through his work at the airport. That sounded like a solid plan.

Before we headed for the court, however, we stopped at a

large pastry shop. In the midst of mountains of pastries and cakes, we got a box of the house's best pistachio cookies for the equivalent of 10 euros. I was surprised at such a gift, but that is just how things seemed to work here. The court was only about 200 meters away. At the entrance, we had to hand over our cell phones, then we entered the office of the judge.

He was a very serious man with a large scar on his cheek. Four fingers were missing from his left hand, injuries from the war that had probably helped him get into this position. We will call him Scarface from here on. Saleh explained the situation to him. At first, Scarface did not seem particularly helpful and just looked grim. Only when we showed him a picture of my Mercedes and I answered some of his questions in English did he thaw. He began to smile, which immediately made him seem more sympathetic. There was tea, the mood loosened up, and he began to make phone calls. First, he called the judge in Jolfa and told him he should either return the case to customs or close it completely. Then he tackled the customs chief and explained to him in a clear tone that they should not unload every bit of nonsense on him; after all, 300 cases from Norduz had landed on his desk last year. Finally, he even talked to Glasses and instructed him to give me my passport back.

I was stunned. Without contacts, I had run into walls, but with Saleh at my side, everything suddenly went smoothly. We left the building, and I had a broad grin on my face. I already saw myself in my mind leaving Iran



with the car tomorrow.

However, the problem remained with my visa, which expired exactly on that day. Saleh made a call, and we drove to the foreigners' police. There, Saleh obviously knew everyone; there were hugs and warm greetings. While the details were being discussed upstairs, Saleh sent Payam off to get supplies: new cookies for the chief of the foreigners' authority.

Payam came back with a similar box. We entered the office, showed the copy of my ID with the handwritten note, and explained the situation. The chief was very friendly, asked if a 20-day extension would be enough, and ordered tea again. The three talked animatedly in Farsi. I did not understand a word, but I did not care; all problems seemed to vanish into thin air. Then an employee came in with a serious face and explained that they could not extend the visa in the system without the original passport. There was a short discussion until the chief hit the table with his finger and made it clear that a working solution had to be found. The employee finally brought a piece of paper that Saleh filled out and I signed. I was told to just come back with my passport to add everything later, but until then everything was fine.

Upon leaving, however, something became clear to me. Now the system stated that there was a problem with my passport. My plan B, to simply leave with the second passport, had suddenly become more dangerous. In that moment, however, I suppressed the thought; after all, I

wanted to leave the country tomorrow with my Mercedes.

# Between Lamb Chops and Existential Dread

The next morning dawns early. Payam has continued to leave me his room and sleeps on the large couch in the living room himself. Without breakfast, we pick up Saleh and drive directly to the court to finally conclude the matter.

Saleh goes to the judge alone while Payam and I wait outside in the hallway. After a while, an employee brings tea into the judge's chambers, which I take for a good sign. But when Saleh finally comes out, he immediately dampens my expectations. He explains that although the judge is not personally against me, he cannot simply drop the case. Since the process has already been officially initiated, the risk of corruption allegations within the system is too high.

The judge has told Saleh of a new possibility: the customs chief in Tabriz could stop the proceedings since customs is the official plaintiff in this case. That leaves us with only two options. Either I accept the situation and risk imprisonment without the \$48,000, or we try to convince the customs chief to drop the case. The decision is not difficult for us.

On the way back to Tabriz, we stop at an old farmer by the roadside at 2:00 PM and buy apples. It is the first time that day that I eat anything. Arriving in Tabriz, however, the plans change unexpectedly. Saleh seems not to have reached the customs chief. Instead, we head for a new building to pick up the keys for his new apartment. As usual, we stop at a pastry shop beforehand to get sweets for the handover.

We enter a large assembly room. At the end of a long table sits a real estate agent in a fancy suit with a mischievous smile. Next to him, his significantly younger assistant, clad entirely in black and very dressed up. Both eye me interestedly; foreigners are probably rarely seen here. I smile politely back, but actually have no head for small talk. Saleh begins the conversation and finally tells them my whole story, including the court trial. While they chat, they start to joke a bit. "Just stay here and get married," they say laughing. The assistant giggles and tells of a friend who is learning English to marry a man from Europe. Actually, it is a normal reaction, but in my situation, a claustrophobic feeling overcomes me. I feel like in a bad movie. I stand with one leg in prison and here jokes are being made of which I barely understand a word. A roar fills my ears, everything around me becomes blurred. It is impossible to grasp a clear thought in this absurd situation.

After about 20 seconds, the roar subsides. The assistant says something that Payam translates for me: "The way he looks, he's been locked up here since the second World

War.” I notice that I have to pull myself together, but Saleh and Payam also look concerned now. The lightness in the room has disappeared. We handle the formalities, take the keys, and briefly inspect the apartment.

Then we drive to an upscale restaurant and order the most expensive dish on the menu: super tender lamb chops skewered on a kind of sword. Per person, that costs only about 10 euros. During the meal, my condition stabilizes somewhat. The enormous stress of the last week and a half and the empty stomach have pushed me completely to the limit physically and mentally. With every bite, energy slowly returns.

On the way, as we bring Saleh home, I type a message into my translator and show it to him:

”I know that it is absolutely not something to take for granted for me. I never forget when someone does me a favor, especially not in such a big matter. Let me know if I can ever do anything for you, no matter what it is. I am sorry that I lost my composure earlier. It was just a bit too much.”

Saleh reads the lines silently. He looks really moved for a moment. From his gaze, I immediately notice that he very much appreciates that I communicated this recognition to him so directly.

At 10:00 PM, we still meet with an experienced customs inspector at the airport. He helps us draft a letter to

convince the customs chief to finally drop the proceedings. We spend about two hours in his small office while he writes the document. Again and again, he asks detailed questions that Payam patiently answers for him. When we finally leave the office, we are the only remaining guests in the terminal. In the emptiness of the building, I notice that a man from the Iranian secret service is following us somewhat conspicuously. I don't think much of it at this moment; I am simply glad that this long day is coming to an end.

# Bureaucratic Standstill

In Iran, Thursday marks the beginning of the weekend. As on the days before, I woke up with an oppressive pressure in my chest, a feeling I felt in this form for the first time in my life. It resembled a feeling of panic, but without the palpitations. This pressure usually persisted for hours after waking up and only subsided somewhat in the course of the day. For me, this day meant above all one thing: standstill. When the authorities close, absolutely nothing happens in this country anymore. It was a strange feeling. On the one hand, it gnawed at me that for two days nothing would progress, while my time and my visa were running out. On the other hand, it was urgently necessary to get some sleep for once and regain strength after the stress of the last week and a half.

We used the time for a few organizational things. The letter the customs inspector had drafted the night before was only handwritten. In Iran, it is a common combination to first create a handwritten document and then visit a copy shop to have it typed up. So we went looking for a shop that offers this service. On this occasion, we also directly printed a copy of my Carnet de Passage and the letter from the German embassy that I had received on Tuesday morning. The rest of the day we spent at the

bazaar to do some errands.

Friday passed quietly. We only met with Saleh and the customs officer in charge of the airport to go through the collected papers one last time. We wanted to ensure that everything is ready when we go to the customs in Tabriz the next day. The assessment of the experts on site was positive: The documents we now had together should be sufficient to have the charges against me dropped.

The next morning we made our way to the customs, but the disappointment followed immediately: The chief was not in his office. We were told he would only come back in the afternoon. To use the time sensibly, we drove by Scarface again to find out the current status from his perspective. His judgment, however, was little encouraging. He informed us that I would have to go to court again for my final defense. There was nothing to shake about the bail; it was not negotiable. If I did not raise the sum, the path to prison would remain the only consequence.

On the way back from the customs office, my phone vibrated. A voice message from Reza, a friend from Hamburg with whom I lived before my journey. He had asked a friendly Mullah in Tehran to help me out of my situation.

The result, however, was negative: The contact refused any support. Someone from the Mullah's team had checked me in the system and found that a so-called red flag had been set on me. This means that the secret service has an eye on me. Who initiated this



entry, they could not say, as even the query of this information in the system leaves traceable marks. Reza urgently advised me to keep a low profile. He speaks from experience: As a German-Iranian, he himself sat in an Iranian prison for nine months a few years ago because he was suspected of espionage.

It was one of those moments when you think it can't go any further downhill, and then the next bad news comes around the corner. But after the last week and a half, this warning felt almost like another just one more burden to carry. My rational thought was: If the secret service really had something solid against me, they probably would have gotten me long ago. Nevertheless, I had absolutely no desire for an hours-long interrogation during my planned departure.

I decided not to tell anyone about it. Although Payam and I were now good friends and spoke openly about everything, the danger was too great to let him in. Had he broken off contact out of fear, I would have been completely alone again, without any point of departure for solving my situation. I also told my parents and friends in Germany nothing, so as not to worry them even more.

So we drove silently back to the customs, in the hope of finally meeting the chief in the afternoon. But this time, too, his seat was empty. It is a frustrating experience how often in Iran key personnel are simply not to be found at their workplace when it matters most.

# A Glimmer of Hope with Obstacles

The next day began promisingly. We drove early in the morning directly to the customs and this time actually had success: The assistant to the chief took time to listen to us. After the usual back and forth, real progress emerged. The chief decided to request an official statement from the border in Norduz. For me, that was a small glimmer of hope in this bureaucratic thicket, even if we were only supposed to come back on Tuesday.

Since we wanted to lose no time, we picked up Saleh and immediately set out on the way back to Norduz. We wanted to personally ensure that the communication between the authorities does not fizzle out.

Arriving at the border, we directly sought a conversation with Glasses. But there was no sign of cooperation. Although Scarface had instructed him to give me my passport back, he resorted to a brazen lie and claimed all my documents were already at the court. As turned out later, that was a flat lie, which one could already see in his behavior at that moment.

I again understood not a word of the heated discussion,

but noticed how the mood turned dangerously. Saleh talked ever more energetically to him, while Glasses visibly enjoyed the moment. He seemed to drunk on the power he had over me in this instant. Payam and Saleh afterwards remained silent about what Glasses had exactly said. Why they withheld the details from me remains a mystery to me to this day. I simply did not know in this moment where the actual problem lay. Today I assume that a crucial puzzle piece was missing for us: The customs in Tabriz could factually not help me at all, since the true decision-making power lay in Tehran. But at that time, we had no connection there and desperately tried to settle things on site.

Following this, Saleh talked relatively long with the mustachioed customs chief of Norduz. At the end, both seemed satisfied with the conversation. The chief gave Saleh his word that they would not go into appeal. For me, that changed little; after all the lies, it was clear to me that I could in no way trust these people and their promises.

After this exhausting day, we started the almost three-hour return journey. It was an exhausting way, and deep inside I already suspected that it would not have been the last time we had to put this stretch behind us. Despite the uncertainty, our decision became certain: We would appear at the customs in Tabriz again the next day. In our situation, there was nothing more to lose anyway.

# A Lawyer Is Needed

The next morning we drove as planned to the customs in Tabriz. As already expected, we were told by the assistant that the charges could not be withdrawn. He also read to Payam the requested assessment from Norduz. Glasses had now clearly written therein that he also no longer assumed that I wanted to smuggle the car. He also admitted that the previously calculated value of \$16,000 was set clearly too high. Nevertheless, the charges could not be withdrawn, as the customs did not know what the car was used for in the last months of my absence. But they assured us: If the court should ask, they would definitely put in a good word for me.

Even though the situation had not really improved, we learned that we needed a certificate about where the car had remained the whole time. We called Razool in Shiraz, with whom the Mercedes was parked. He told of a good contact to a Mr. Haghidat from the Automobile Club. He could issue me a confirmation with an official stamp. Payam called him. This man was really a blessing: He made everything ready the next day and sent it to us by e-mail.

After all our attempts, there was no way out: I had to go to court. For that, I needed a lawyer. We had already

informed ourselves about various possibilities. Most lawyers made it clear to us that I was in a huge problem. They demanded a fee of at least 10% of the amount in dispute, which in my case at that time corresponded to \$4,800. I was not ready to pay such a sum. Already a few days before, an old acquaintance I had met in Portugal had sent me a number of a lawyer from Jolfa. He had received this recommendation through the grapevine after my Instagram post. Payam called him. He simply said: "Drop by and we'll see."

Arriving in Jolfa, we finally found the right address after a few orientation problems. The lawyer received us directly outside on the street. He was a kindly smiling man who at first glance seemed rather reserved. We went into his office, handed him all documents, and Payam told him the whole story. At the end, Payam made it unmistakably clear to him that there was not much to be had from me financially. We said goodbye and subsequently drove back to the already well-known hotel in Norduz.

# The Seal of Ink and Tears

The next morning we met at a large roundabout in Jolfa. The lawyer looked much more dressed up today than the day before. He explained to me that my situation was legally quite clear and the evidence was on my side. His offer for the defense was just 200 euros. Compared to the 4,800 dollars we had feared after the first conversations with other lawyers, that was a huge difference. We agreed immediately. He pulled out a power of attorney, which I signed and sealed with my fingerprint. We made it unmistakably clear to him once more that our biggest problem was the bail, because I did not want to go to prison under any circumstances. He promised to go to court and clarify the further proceedings directly with the judge.

Since we could not achieve much more on this day, we drove along the Aras, the border river to Armenia. We came to a small village that seemed to consist almost only of fishermen. Payam knew some people there because he had previously frequently mediated business between the local fishermen and international buyers. The quality of the catch was impressive. We talked about whether one

could possibly export this fish to Russia or Germany. In the end, we ordered two portions of fried fish from today's catch. It was simply delicious. I love these moments in remote villages where one can enjoy the simplicity of a kitchen with fresh local ingredients. But exactly there the call of the lawyer reached us. He already had a first feedback from the court: The judge had given us an official appointment for Monday morning. Thus the end of the uncertainty was dated, which immediately changed the mood at the table.

On the way back to Tabriz, however, my thoughts began to race. The confrontation with the court in Jolfa had now become inescapable. The situation felt oppressive:

- I still had to expect to go to prison, as I saw no possibility of raising the bail of 48,000 dollars.
- The aircraft carrier Abraham Lincoln still lay directly off the Persian Gulf.
- Payam tried to call people to find options for the bail, but none of it sounded helpful in any way.

I did not know what to do and remembered Zahra. She is a Georgian-Iranian woman from Iran who has been living in Tbilisi for a few years now. We had a romance that I don't want to go into more detail about. We had not separated in a fight, but felt not on good terms either. I remembered that she had frequently mentioned

her vacant condominium in Tehran. The mere thought of having to ask her of all people for help scratched massively at my ego. Normally I pull myself out of the swamp single-handedly like Baron Munchausen. But this time it felt as if I had been stripped of my dignity.

The decision to ask Zahra for help in my desperation triggered something in me. In the moment I made the decision in my head, tears suddenly ran down my face. I could do nothing against it. It was not real crying; the tears just streamed from my eyes. I had never experienced something like that before. I think Payam noticed it at the wheel, but we remained silent for a while. When he finally asked me something, I was surprised how clearly I could answer, although my eyes were still tearing.

After some time we stopped at a gas station and got some soul food in the form of sweet pastries. I felt a bit better afterwards. It is amazing how crying can affect the human psyche: When we arrived about an hour later at Payam's in Tabriz, I felt really good, significantly better than the days before. We ate dinner and I lay down for a bit after all the stress. After a few hours I went back to the living room. Payam reported to me that the lawyer had contacted him. He had actually accomplished it: The judge had decided to suspend the bail. For the time being at least, as it would turn out later. Through this news, it finally became unnecessary to actually contact Zahra.



# Waiting, Waiting

Wednesday. A holiday before the weekend and the beginning of another phase of waiting. Before Saturday we can do absolutely nothing. It is exactly the same bad feeling as the week before: a mixture of powerlessness and this nervous restlessness that arises when one is condemned to inactivity. To fill the time somehow and get our heads clear, we make a few excursions. One of them leads us to Kandovan, the Iranian Cappadocia. The ancient dwellings carved into the rock are impressive, but in the back of my mind the clock is constantly ticking, which is actually standing still.

On Saturday we stand again at the customs assistant in Tabriz. We hope for a written statement for the court, a document that could exonerate me. But the answer remains dry and bureaucratic: The letter is denied us. There is no progress, only the realization that we continue to turn in circles. So it means again: waiting.

On Sunday, while we are just doing some shopping, Payam's phone rings. My lawyer is on it. The message is short and sobering: The trial was postponed again, this time to Tuesday at 8:00 AM. Great, more waiting. I can hardly contain myself with joy. To be honest, I can no longer remember exactly what happened after that until

the court appointment. I fell into a slightly depressive phase. The constant uncertainty and the feeling of being stuck in the system have worn me down.

# Day of Judgment

The time has come. My appointment with the judge is finally pending. So that the proceedings can take place at all, the court prescribes an official translator. But they cannot provide one for me. Payam and I have therefore taken care of it ourselves and already met a man in Tabriz on Thursday who is supposed to take over this job: Mr. Translation. He is about 1.85 meters tall, well dressed, and of stout nature. A mischievous grin lies on his lips as we meet him punctually in front of the court building in Jolfa and go in together.

Somewhat nervous, I enter the judge's chambers, which I already know from my previous visits. The scenery is unchanged: The judge is enthroned behind his wooden table, and the metal chairs are still in their protective plastic packaging. I take the place directly opposite the judge. Next to me sits Mr. Translation. Payam initially sat down in the row of chairs on the right, but the judge asks him shortly thereafter to leave the room.

Two key figures are still missing at the beginning: My lawyer and Glasses. So we start without them with the recording of my personal details. That this is not a purely bureaucratic act in Iran, I notice at the latest with the religion question.

"What is your religion?", asks Mr. Translation.

"Agnostic," I answer.

"What's this?", he replies with a completely confused look.

In this moment, it seems to me little expedient to hold a philosophical treatise on the concept of agnosticism. So I just say: "Atheist."

"You can't say this here!", he answers with wide eyes.

Okay, then I am: "Christian." Since I am even baptized twice, that corresponds in a certain way to the truth. In retrospect, I learn that for this protocol there are only four passable answers: Shiite, Sunni, Christian, or Jew.

Shortly thereafter, the lawyer enters the room and immediately begins to study my court documents. He doesn't really seem well prepared, but for the money I probably can't expect more. The judge informs me that I have the right to remain silent and let my lawyer speak for me. I decline and begin to tell the entire story from the beginning. While I speak, my lawyer takes a DIN A4 notepad and begins to take notes.

I report how I came to Iran on March 17. I tell where I stayed the first two months. That I actually wanted to go to Nepal and how the India-Pakistan conflict blocked my way. Also the acquaintance with Alen, the Croat, I mention. In the meantime, Glasses also enters the room. He carries my file with him, in which my passport is firmly

glued. So much for the claim that the document was already at the court, as he wanted to make us believe days ago. I do not let his presence distract me and continue telling.

For the judge, a central point is where the car had remained. He wants to know whether it stood on private property, whether someone else had access to it, and whether repairs were carried out in my absence. I also mention that in my Carnet de Passage upon entry no exit date at all had been noted. That is a significant point, because legally the border officials are obliged to tell me an exact time for the exit of the car. The judge reads out the corresponding law text.

Glasses doesn't like this moment at all. After the judge is finished, he leaves the room to make a phone call. I don't know exactly with whom he speaks, in any case he comes back shortly thereafter and tries to argue against it. It doesn't look as if that meets with favor from the judge. Finally, he simply claims brazenly that on my Carnet it says the car may only stay in the country for one month. When I hold the copy up to him, he apparently cannot find the place. I end my defense with the statement that I am just a traveler who simply did not know the Iranian law better and listened to the wrong people.

Now it's Glasses' turn. As prosecutor, he tries for about ten minutes to convince the judge that I must be punished for smuggling. The judge doesn't seem to let himself be changed. Visibly disappointed, Glasses sits down on his

place again and starts to write in the same notepad in which the lawyer has protocolled my statements.

Before I finally set the signatures under the protocol, the judge instructs us that he wants to have the original letter regarding the car's whereabouts, as this so far is only available in print. Furthermore, he demands a receipt for the repairs and a translation of my Carnet until Saturday. He assures us that then all necessary evidence is together to prove that I had not smuggled the car and thus was innocent.

The judge now explains how it goes on, but Mr. Translation translates absolutely nothing of it. In general, in the course of the proceedings I only got communicated the most necessary points. When Glasses is finished with his transcript, I am called forward. I am now supposed to sign all statements that my lawyer has written down and stamp them with my fingerprint. After about two hours we leave the judge's chambers.

I feel good. It is like a liberation. The session apparently was quite exhausting for everyone, so we go outside together without talking much. The lawyer still says a few things to Payam and says goodbye. Since I got communicated no information at all about the further proceedings translated, I firmly assume that I can finally leave the country with my car in a few days. Everything seems to have gone quite well.

When the translator already wants to go, I speak to him once more about it. He explains to me with a slight grin

that it will take at least one month. His grin becomes significantly wider as he adds that it will probably rather be four to five months. While he says that in his strangely joyful way, I have the brief impulse to hit him in the face. What is wrong with this guy? It is his job to translate the statements in court for me, he does not comply with it and in the end even makes fun of my situation?

The time data come about as follows: After the verdict is written, the customs has 20 days time to go into appeal against it. In the ideal case, it therefore takes about one month. But the judge also mentions that the customs usually files an appeal. That can then well and truly take half a year.

And then there was one more thing. The bail is only suspended until the verdict. That is also only told to me now. That means, as soon as the verdict stands and the 20 days period begins, I would have to wait in prison. In case the customs contests the verdict, I would sit in the slammer the entire time. One positive turn there is at least: The bail was lowered from the triple to the single vehicle value. Since the war-threatened national currency has fallen further, that corresponds now to about 12,000 euros. Not 48,000 dollars anymore, but still no sum that I simply have lying around.

The entire euphoria after the successful court appointment is shattered. The loop in my head starts again: After one positive thing, the next bad news follows directly.

# In Khoy, Around Khoy, and All Around Khoy

On the way to Tabriz we discussed the further proceedings. We were almost at the goal, but the bail was still outstanding. We had talked before about the fact that it is common in Iran that someone else provides the bail if one cannot pay it oneself. However, these people usually pocket 15 to 20% of the amount. Since the bail had been downgraded somewhat, this way out suddenly became affordable. Payam called his friend Nasir from the city of Khoy. Nasir has a larger area of land that is worth at least three times my bail. They agreed to pull it off for 10%. Given the choice of either paying 1,200 euros or having to witness a war in prison, the decision was incredibly easy for me. So we agreed to drive together to court on Saturday to settle everything. Why Saturday? Because on Wednesday was of course again a holiday. So again: waiting...

It's truly fascinating to observe how the mind adapts in the course of such a situation. In the beginning, one is fully focused, one wants to take in and understand every single step. One has the feeling that in this moment one really must do everything and somehow can also do



something to solve the situation. This focus decreases with time. Almost four weeks after I came to the border, not much was left of it. I had really gotten used to simply accepting things. Don't get me wrong: It is not a feeling of giving up, but rather the realization that one cannot really move anything. One falls into an I-don't-give-a-damn attitude. What happens, happens. One is drained and has learned that hope brings nothing. True to the motto: one step forward, two back.

The time had come, Saturday. Once again. We drove in a good mood early in the morning to Khoy to pick up Nasir. In Khoy, a relatively small, kindly smiling man got in, whose beard grew until just below the eyes. He had a flatbread with him, which was traditionally filled with potatoes, egg, and herbs, and offered us a piece. We declined politely and set out on the way to the about 80 kilometers distant court in Jolfa. Arriving there, the groomed assistant explained to us that we must go to the Tazirat (smuggling court) in Khoy. Since Nasir's land lies in another region, it could not be accepted here as bail. Before that, however, they would have to make an inquiry, and the whole thing must be handled within one day, otherwise prison threatened. Such a statement shocked me meanwhile hardly anymore. We were supposed to come back the next morning to pick up the inquiry for Khoy. We brought Nasir back to his car and drove to the well-known border hotel in Norduz.

The next day we drove early in the morning to the Tazirat in Jolfa and then further to Khoy, where Nasir was

already waiting for us. There they gave us a letter for the Land Department. Back at the Tazirat, however, they told us that the land cannot be accepted that way because it was farmland and not building land. Payam made jokes about the fact that it probably again comes down to Saturday. I made it clear to him that I was really not in the mood for such jokes right now. We called Saleh, he called Scarface, and he spoke with my judge. We contacted the lawyer so that he should go to the Tazirat in Jolfa to investigate the matter. He said he was nearby anyway and would do it directly. Everything again took a felt eternity. I had to think of Zahra again, but discarded the thought for the time being. The lawyer called back and said the assistant remained at it: With such a sum, farmland could not be accepted. Great... We called the lawyer again and told him he should speak personally with the judge. He agreed. Again an eternity passed until the call back came: The farmland is accepted as bail after all. At 1:55 PM we got the new letter for the Land Department. Since at 2:00 PM all state facilities close, we could unfortunately not achieve anything more on this day.

We set out on the way to Nasir's actual business. He operates a kind of bathhouse in the mountains shortly before the Turkish border. There water from hot springs is pumped up into large basins. Of course there are separate men's and women's baths. We relaxed for some time in the hot water and subsequently retired to a small cottage that Nasir had provided for us there. Besides an

employee, Payam and I were the only ones who spent the night there, because at night in the mountains it was just still very cold. I placed my thin mat directly next to the space heater, on whose other side Payam slept. Otherwise it would have become a really uncomfortably cold night.

The next morning dawned. We drove through the sun-lit Kurdish mountains back to Khoy to the Land Department. There we were informed that a bail was still open on the land. Nasir told us that he had once provided it for his brother and it had actually already been redeemed eight years ago; but that didn't seem to have been updated everywhere in the system. We drove to the main court in Khoy to find out where the problem lay. Since the next regular appointments were only free in a week, we got a box of cookies and drove to an office that can issue appointments. Thanks to the box, Nasir got a direct appointment on the same day. It's amazing what a few cookies can do. We waited two hours at the main court and were then sent to the Tazirat. We still had to go to the bank, which was also involved in the topic. At 2:10 PM we arrived at the Tazirat. It was closed, but someone nevertheless opened for us. Nasir spoke briefly with the man, who seemed to remember the case and asked us to come back the next day. We looked at Khoy a bit and stayed the night there in an apartment.

On Tuesday we set out in the morning again to the Tazirat and received a letter. We again went to the pastry shop and got a new box for the bank. It reacted to the

gift quite quickly, but said they still needed a letter from the main court. There we waited again. This time four hours! I was never a patient person, but in this time I probably became one. At 1:55 PM they finally found the right file in court. Since Payam and I could anyway not achieve anything more there, we agreed that we drive back to Norduz and Nasir handles the matter in Khoy alone.

# Glasses' Mocking Grin

The next morning we leave the hotel in Norduz and make our way to the border. Our goal is the office of the mustachioed customs chief: We want to convince him to finally stamp my Carnet de Passage. Strictly speaking, the Mercedes has already left Iran, as it stands safely kept behind the first barrier on the border area. Payam takes over the mediation as usual, while I listen to the sound of the Persian words without being able to grasp their content. When we leave the room after a felt eternity, Payam reports to me of a surprising turn. The customs chief has assured that they would not file an appeal against the coming court verdict. That means that I do not have to wait the usual twenty days until the verdict is legally valid and I may export the car. As soon as the document is available, they wanted to send a letter to the judge so that the matter can be concluded on the same day.

In this moment, a euphoria streams through me that I have not felt for weeks. The real prospect of actually leaving Iran with my Mercedes I have internally almost already given up. But as this country is full of surprises, the next punch to the gut follows immediately upon every glimmer of hope. Payam learns incidentally that the penalty fees for paragraph 109, the exceeding of the stay

duration for vehicles, were drastically increased. If one day of delay used to cost about 1.50 euros, the system now demands 800,000 Toman, which according to Payam corresponds to about 40 euros per day. Even without recalculating all that, it is immediately clear to me that this journey remains a financial catastrophe. Even if I am acquitted of the smuggling charge, this horrendous penalty remains. My euphoria is instantly gone.

In the midst of this disillusionment bursts the call from Nasir: He has actually made it and deposited the bail in Khoy. The emotional tango tears me around again, because this news is the key to my passport. We wait about an hour until Glasses ambles in at the border. He hardly pays attention to us and first exchanges extensively with his colleagues. When we finally catch him and Payam reports to him of the deposited security, he reacts with a dry: "I don't believe you". In this moment I couldn't help but think that we don't see things as they are, we see them as we are.

Glasses ignores every further attempt at clarification and flees to the assistant of the customs chief, with whom we have maintained a quite positive relationship so far. Payam doesn't let up, follows him, and explains the situation to the assistant: We must know whether I can leave with the passport and how my current status is noted in the system. Glasses finally realizes that his childish power trip wasn't working here, and reluctantly agreed to talk. Since the official confirmation from the court is still on the way, he orders a security official who should take my

passport and accompany us to the passport control. It takes another hour until he appears. During the waiting time, Glasses grins at me self-complacently through the pane of his office; I return his mocking face with nothing but pure contempt.

At the passport control the next bureaucratic hurdle awaited: My visa is expired. One explains to me that I must first seek out the foreigners' police to receive an exit permit. It is no surprise, but at least the last steps in the direction of freedom now become more tangible. The official brings my passport back to Glasses. We called in the meantime with the court to accelerate the transmission of the bail confirmation. When Glasses finally receives the decisive call, he lets us wait another 45 minutes for the demonstration of his remaining power. Then he finally hands me the passport and laughs: "Here's your passport, finally". I take the document silently and feel again only deep contempt for this person who has brought me into this situation and now believes to be able to make jokes about it. We leave the border area and spend the rest of the day in Norduz, while freedom seems within reach.

# Between Notaries, Lambs, and Lobster

Thursday morning greeted us around 6:00 AM with a gentleness that didn't match my inner tension at all. In the Armenian border area lay a breath of spring in the air, warm and sunny. Actually the plan was simple: We wanted to drive to a friend of Payam in the neighboring province Ardabil to pick up a freshly slaughtered sheep. But as soon as we were in the car, we realized that this place was five hours away and thus absolutely not on our way. We changed the course therefore first once back to Tabriz, because I was still missing a decisive puzzle piece for my departure: a power of attorney for the Mercedes in Payam's name. I didn't know whether I would ever receive a visa for Iran again, and wanted to have the car transferred to him for security. With this project we had already dealt a few days ago in Khoy, to be honest with only very little success. As soon as the notaries noticed that I speak no Farsi, they waved away. Five offices we had unsuccessfully scoured.

Time was running out and in Tabriz we hoped for better chances. However, most service providers close on Thursday at 12:00 noon, so we had to hurry. Arriving



in Tabriz, we scoured some notaries and at the fourth we had actually finally luck. It was clear to us that we would need a translator, so Mr. Translation was informed immediately and he headed right over. He took significantly longer than expected, however, although the place lay quite close to his office. The office of the notary lay near a mosque and it turned out that he had gone to the wrong mosque first. When he arrived shortly before 12:00 noon, a discussion began that Mr. Translation translated only into English and not into German. But there was not a single German translator in the entire province. Since the state servers for the processing of notarial documents go offline at exactly 12:00 noon, we could unfortunately not conclude that anymore. Come back on Saturday...

Somewhat annoyed that it had not worked out on this day, I was nevertheless pleased that we had finally found a possibility for the power of attorney. Like almost every day when we were in Tabriz, we picked up Payam's father from work, brought him home, and set out thereupon on the long way to Ardabil. The landscape, which at first was still barren and dusty, transformed behind a mountain pass suddenly into a deep, lush green. This green landscape improved the mood directly. It is again and again exciting and amazing how quickly landscapes can change. Around 6:00 PM we reached the village of the friend, a very active, pithy type with only few remaining teeth. Already before we arrived, we had spoken about spending the night there, however I had somehow a better feeling thereby to drive back again. I can not

describe exactly on what that lay. Payam wanted rather to stay, because he had already been driving really the whole day, but I could persuade him after some back and forth. Above all, because we had promised his father for weeks to drive with him to his home village the next day. At Abgousht, cake, and tea we spent about two hours there, took the meat with us, and set out.

After the first hour I took the wheel. After short time Payam fell asleep and I chauffeured us back to Tabriz. I really enjoyed driving again, as it had been quite a while. At this time the roads were no longer so frequented, which suited me quite well. Even if one is on the way in Iran during the day and thinks that the people drive crazy, the madness on the roads only starts as soon as it gets dark. Since there are apparently no guidelines for light at the car, there are very many light sources in all possible colors that can blind one. If one still gets along with that, there are however still the drivers who come racing from behind and imitate a stroboscope storm with their headlight flasher. Thereby is also completely indifferent to whether you can make way or not. Sometimes I have the feeling that the Iranians compensate their extremely positive interpersonal way of life with a highly aggressive driving style. But after four months on Iran's roads one gets used to it too. After a day on which we had spent 15 hours in the car, we arrived back in Tabriz at 2:00 AM.

We slept out a bit and set out on the way into the village. There we arrived at an old house in a rather dilapidated condition. Payam's father and a man had made a few

works on the yard. We took care of the food. Even if the place was somehow a small idyll, it raced in my head. The point with the penalty for paragraph 109 was breathing down my neck. I could not settle the new sum. After some time I spoke to Payam once more about it and whether we would have possibilities to bypass that or to reduce the sum. Payam called Saleh and I understood that from the telephone call something developed what seemed positive. Saleh calculated again. 800,000 Toman are no 40 euros, they are 4 euros... I should have figured that out myself. But as said: I was meanwhile in a condition in which one rather bluntly takes the things instead of questioning them critically. In this moment a huge stone fell from my heart. That had been the last point that had really been continuously eating at me.

The next morning we met as first with Mr. Translation at the notary. The power of attorney was written down, Mr. Translation translated the content, I signed. That went really smoothly for once. Now came the last critical point: the way to the foreigners' police. Once arrived there, the ping-pong started all over again. After we had spoken to what felt like every employee, they brought us to the chief, who granted me the 20 days extension. He said only that I should pay the penalty for the 10 days that I am over. 4,000,000 Toman are just under 20 euros. Considering how serious everything had looked, it was of course my smallest problem. At the end however the disillusionment came. They kept my pass there for the verification for one day. Immediately the alarm bells went on again at

me, because the warning about my Red Flag was still haunting me. The fact that shortly before already two men in the queue before us had been sent directly to the secret service hadn't made things any better. That was absolutely no good sign.

Payam called the lawyer so that he requested at the judge whether he would write the verdict. Time was running out. I wanted to get out, and that at best at the wheel of my own car. The lawyer however achieved nothing at the judge. The only thing that remained for us was to ask Scarface for help again the next morning. In the evening I lay in bed and looked at Insta stories. Most news I receive from worldpolitics\_daily. There I saw a picture how on this day the US troops in the Middle East were served steak, pie, crab legs, and lobster. With the headline "Who knows, knows" it became clear to me immediately what that has to mean. To everyone who knows a bit about it, the heart stands still at this sight, since it is often the last meal before a big assignment. This panic, that I had certainly not felt since two weeks, rose again in me. It was clearly time to leave the country.

# Tourist, Tourist

It is Sunday. At 8:30 AM we stand in Scarface's office. There exists the theoretical chance that he calls the judge and the verdict is still passed today. After a short conversation is clear: nothing comes of it. Another bureaucratic standstill.

We drive again to the foreigners' police. Since we are too early, we must wait 15 minutes. I am clearly more tense than usual. Every minute in this building feels tough. I sit in the waiting area, while Payam clarifies the formalities. Suddenly one of the telephones rings. It stands not directly at the place of the official, but a bit aside. It is the same telephone over which yesterday the instruction came that the two men before us had to present themselves at the secret service. My heart sank while the official is on the telephone and parallel speaks with Payam. After a felt eternity Payam turns around. He holds my pass in the hand.

I may actually leave the country. Payam must however transmit his own personal details over the telephone. We are both unsure what that means for him. One thing is clear to me however: Had he not been there, I would have had to start the way to the secret service.

The last drive to Norduz goes by like a flight. I am excited to be able to leave the country soon. Actually everything is ready for my departure, but the written verdict keeps us waiting. Since my Carnet expires in two weeks, we ask one last time whether they can not stamp it in advance. The fact that the car and the Carnet would remain as collateral until the matter was officially clarified went without saying. The answer is nevertheless a clear no. At least I would receive a document after the verdict confirming when I arrived at the border and that the car has been there ever since. In this situation that is at least a small straw.

I go one last time to the W124. While I cleared out the last of my things and stowed others, the owner of an Austrian off-road car suddenly appeared. He parks directly next to me. It is surreal: Over a month I have spent at this border and seen no single European, and exactly in this moment stands someone from a neighboring country before me. He is with a guide on the way and has a similar problem: He must leave his car because of a defect in the country, even if not as long as I.

I tell him briefly my story. He stares at me with big eyes. I smile and say to him that he fortunately only must pay the penalty for paragraph 109 and has no charge because of smuggling hanging over my head. I notice how unsure he was. It reminds me of myself five weeks ago: clueless about what was really going on. I couldn't help but smirk. My perspective has completely changed. I am blunt. While he and his guide set out to the hotel,

I go in the opposite direction.

Before the passport control a long queue has formed. That is unusual, normally this area was almost empty. While I wait, a man from the secret service eyed me from the side. He beckons me to himself. Great. In my head I see already the hour-long interrogation before me.

"What are you doing in Iran?", he asks in very poor English.

"Tourist!", I answer.

He tries to follow up, but his vocabulary doesn't suffice.

I repeat only: "Tourist, Tourist".

He takes my pass and examines about one minute long the stamps of my journey. He sees me briefly in the eyes and lets me then go. No further questions. No interrogation.

The time had come. I left Iran on February 22, 2026. Exactly six days before the Americans began Operation Epic Fury.

# Epilogue

I stayed another week in Armenia and looked back over the border, in the hope the judge would finally bring the verdict to paper. But when the Americans attacked and it became certain that Khamenei was dead, I grasped that my Mercedes in this chaos so fast would have no more priority. I booked very spontaneously a ticket to Germany. It felt surreal to return after all that time at the end yet without the car. Anyone who knows me knows what that did to me. The W124 was for me far more than only steel; it was my home on wheels, my faithful tank.

Meanwhile, two months have passed since I left Iran. A few days ago the news reached me that the verdict has now finally been written and the appeal period of twenty days runs. With a bit of luck I can soon travel back again to the Armenian-Iranian border to bring my actual journey yet to end.

At this point I must say one thing very clearly: Everything that happened to me there had absolutely nothing to do with the fact that I was a foreigner or tourist. The Iranian government is certainly no more lenient with its own population. Currently, there are 25 million open court proceedings in Iran, with a population of 93 million



people. For comparison, there are only about one million proceedings in Germany. The discrepancy between the population and the state is greater than in almost any other country. While the state defines itself as Islamic, the population understands itself primarily as Persian. The ratio lies estimated at 20 to 80 percent.

For most people, it remains incomprehensible why I travel to Iran at all. But the main reason is the wonderful people there. The millennia-old culture offers a form of togetherness that in western cultures has often been lost. While one here, especially in the anonymous big cities, often has the feeling that everyone just wants to be left in peace, the collective counts there. If someone asks for help, it is second nature for Iranians not only to support him, but perhaps even to invite him directly home. A guest is there a gift, no burden. Even if someone cuts in line, no one gets upset; one accepts simply that he is probably in a hurry.

This culture is supported by subtleties that have enriched me as a human profoundly. Many of these behavior patterns are foreign to us, above all the principle of *Taarof*, what one could translate freely with politeness. While we use this word in Germany often only incidentally, it is in the Persian culture a real leitmotif. Even if it can sometimes be exhausting when everyone wants to yield precedence on a crowded staircase, this kind of way of living has something very beautiful about it.

Payam's role in my story exemplifies this big heart. He

has helped me in a way as it would hardly another do, without ever expecting anything in return. Ask yourselves how many people in your own environment would stand by a complete stranger so unconditionally.

But despite all hospitality it is for Iranian traders currently extremely difficult to do business abroad. Payam seeks desperately for partners for the export of different goods. Especially in the food sector can be realized currently deals that are lucrative for both sides, since the Iranian currency stands extremely favorable. If there is interest on your part in a professional cooperation, feel free to reach out to me.

In the current situation I honestly don't know yet whether I can pick up the car really soon, but I will definitely let you know!

